



FROM INSIGHT TO INNOVATION

Creative Thinking, Problem
Solving & AI Co-Creation

WHY THIS TOPIC MATTERS

🧩 More Complexity

Business problems are evolving faster than traditional frameworks can handle.

🤖 AI Is Everywhere

Organisations are adopting AI rapidly — yet many still lack the thinking skills to use it well.

🎯 Wrong Problems

Too many teams are solving symptoms rather than root causes.

💡 Innovation Is Mandatory

Standing still is no longer a strategy. Creative thinking is a core professional skill.



What You'll Learn Today

By the end of this session, you will be equipped to:

Think More Creatively

Break out of familiar patterns and generate bolder ideas.

Avoid Decision Traps

Recognise the cognitive biases that derail even smart professionals

Solve Problems Effectively

Dig past symptoms to identify and address root causes.

Use AI as a Thinking Partner

Harness AI to enhance — not replace — your judgement.

ICEBREAKER POLL

Which statement describes you best right now?

- A Understand Creative vs Critical Thinking
- B I have too many ideas and can't choose.
- C have ideas but struggle to decide which to act on.
- D I'm exploring how AI fits into my work.



WHY INTELLIGENCE DOESN'T GUARANTEE GOOD DECISIONS

Even the sharpest minds fall into predictable traps. Recognising them is the first step to avoiding them.

Overconfidence

Overestimating the accuracy of your own judgement.



Time Pressure

Rushing to decide before fully understanding the situation.



Emotional Attachment

Favouring options you're personally invested in.



Authority Bias

Deferring to seniority over evidence.



Fear of Being Wrong

Playing it safe to avoid criticism, even when bold action is needed.



Common Thinking Traps

These four phrases signal that a team's thinking may have already stopped.

“

"This worked before — let's do it again."

”

“

"Let's skip the problem and jump straight to solutions."

”

“

"The boss said so — that's good enough."

”

“

"AI said it, so it must be right."

”

Familiarity and authority are not substitutes for evidence and critical thinking.

REFLECTION

Think about a bad decision you've made

What influenced it most?

Data

Incomplete or misread information.



Emotion

Feelings that overrode the facts.



Pressure

Not enough time to think clearly.



Assumptions

Things you believed without checking





WHAT IS CREATIVE THINKING?

Creative thinking is the ability to move beyond the obvious — to see possibility where others see constraint



Generate Possibilities

Produce a wide range of options before committing to one.



Challenge Assumptions

Question the rules that everyone else takes for granted.



Explore Alternatives

Deliberately consider paths you'd normally dismiss

WHAT IS CRITICAL THINKING?

Critical thinking is the discipline of not accepting ideas at face value — it separates credible insight from compelling noise.



Question Evidence

Ask where data comes from and whether it's reliable.



Evaluate Options

Weigh trade-offs objectively before committing.



Anticipate Risks

Identify what could go wrong before it does.

Why You Need Both

Creative Thinking

Opens up the solution space. Generates options you didn't know were possible.



Critical Thinking

Narrows the solution space. Helps you choose wisely from everything you've generated.

The most effective innovators switch fluidly between these two modes — expanding and contracting their thinking as needed.



THE INNOVATION FORMULA

Creativity Alone

Generates exciting ideas with no filter
— **Chaos.**

Critical Thinking Alone

Evaluates rigorously but generates nothing new — **Stagnation.**

Innovation = Both

Creative ideas, critically selected and rigorously executed — **Breakthrough.**

MINI REFLECTION

Which side are you stronger in?

Creative

You generate plenty of ideas but sometimes struggle to evaluate or choose between them.

Critical

You evaluate ideas rigorously but may hold back from generating bold or unconventional options.

Most teams skew heavily in one direction. Innovation needs both. Which gap does your team need to close?



THE BIGGEST MISTAKE

People solve symptoms — not problems

Fixing what's visible without understanding what's underneath is the fastest way to waste effort and resources





Problem vs Symptom

Take a common business scenario:

"Sales are dropping."

Is that the problem — or merely the symptom?

Dropping sales could be caused by product-market fit issues, a competitor shift, a broken onboarding experience, or poor retention. Treating the symptom with discounts or promotions misses the real issue entirely.

Always ask: what is causing this before deciding what to fix.

Why Teams Solve the Wrong Problem

It's rarely a lack of intelligence. These are the systemic forces that push teams toward the wrong answer:

Pressure

Deadlines reward speed over accuracy. Teams reach for the nearest available solution.

Familiar Solutions

Teams default to what worked last time — even when the context has changed.

Leadership Expectations

When leaders signal a preferred solution, teams stop exploring alternatives.

Discomfort with Uncertainty

Ambiguity is uncomfortable. Acting quickly creates the illusion of progress.

Developed at Toyota, the 5 Whys technique drills past surface symptoms to expose root causes by asking "Why?" repeatedly.

Each "Why?" challenges the previous answer. Most root causes surface within three to five iterations. Stop when you reach something actionable — a process, a behaviour, or a decision that can actually be changed.

Strong Problem Statements define: **Who** is affected, **What** is happening, **Why** it matters, and any known **Constraints**.

5 Whys Analysis

Problem: Ran through a red light

Why?

Late for work

Why?

Woke up late

Why?

Alarm didn't work

Why?

Exhausted battery

Why?

I forgot to check it

Root cause

Now Might We ...

"How might we reduce customer churn by improving the onboarding experience?"

The "How Might We" (HMW) format reframes problems as opportunities. It's open enough to invite creative solutions, yet focused enough to guide action.

Why Brainstorming Often Fails Without Structure



Loud Voices

The most confident speaker dominates. Quieter thinkers stay silent.



Familiar Ideas

Groups converge on safe, predictable options — the ones everyone already knows.



No Structure

Without a framework, sessions drift. Energy is high but output is low.

WHAT IS SCAMPER?

SCAMPER is a brainstorming tool that encourages you to look at a problem or idea from different angles. By applying these 7 techniques, you can unlock new possibilities and develop innovative solutions.



SCAMPER

A creative thinking technique used to generate ideas, solve problems, and improve existing products or processes.

S	C	A	M	P	E	R
SUBSTITUTE	COMBINE	ADAPT	MODIFY / MAGNIFY	PUT TO OTHER USES	ELIMINATE	REVERSE / REARRANGE
						
Replace a part, material, people, or process with something different.	Combine two or more ideas, features, or concepts.	Adapt or copy an idea from elsewhere or change it to fit a new situation.	Modify, change, or magnify (increase or decrease) a part or aspect.	Find new ways to use the idea, product, or resource.	Remove or eliminate parts, features, or steps that are not needed.	Reverse the order, switch roles, or rearrange components.
Example: Use bamboo instead of plastic for toothbrush handles.	Example: Combine a watch with a fitness tracker.	Example: Adapt the self-checkout concept from stores to libraries.	Example: Increase the battery life of a device.	Example: Use coffee grounds as a natural fertilizer.	Example: Eliminate plastic packaging from products.	Example: Reverse the seating direction in a classroom for discussions.



HOW TO USE SCAMPER

Start with your problem or idea. Go through each SCAMPER technique one by one and write down as many ideas as you can. The more ideas, the better!



Best used in teams or brainstorming sessions to spark creativity and innovation.

SCAMPER in Action

Applying SCAMPER to a food delivery service like Grab reveals how each lens generates a distinct line of innovation thinking.



Substitute

Replace drivers with autonomous vehicles or drones for last-mile delivery.



Eliminate

Remove packaging entirely with reusable container subscriptions.



Combine

Bundle grocery shopping with restaurant delivery in a single app experience.



Reverse

Customers collect orders from micro-hubs instead of home delivery.



Creativity Loves Constraints

Counter-intuitively, limitations don't kill creativity — they focus it. Constraints force teams to think more inventively within defined boundaries.

💰 Budget Constraints

Forces prioritisation and resourcefulness over expensive defaults.

🕒 Time Constraints

Encourages decisiveness and eliminates perfectionism paralysis.

🧑‍🤝‍🧑 Resource Constraints

Drives collaboration and creative reuse of existing capabilities.

WHAT COULD YOU ELIMINATE FROM YOUR CURRENT PROCESS?

Removing unnecessary steps, approvals, or meetings is often one of the fastest and most impactful forms of innovation available to any team





AI Will Not Replace Thinking

✗ Bad Thinking + AI

You produce the wrong answer — faster, at greater scale, with more confidence.

✓ Good Thinking + AI

You amplify your best ideas, explore more options, and make sharper decisions.

AI is a multiplier. It amplifies whatever thinking you bring to it — good or

What AI Is Good At

Used well, AI is a powerful co-thinker. These are the tasks where it genuinely adds leverage:

Pattern Recognition

Spots trends and connections across large datasets faster than any human team.

Idea Generation

Produces large volumes of options, angles, and alternatives on demand.

Scenario Building

Models multiple futures and stress-tests decisions against different conditions.

Assumption Discovery

Surfaces hidden assumptions in your reasoning that you may not have noticed.

What AI Is Not Good At

These are the areas where human judgement remains irreplaceable — and where blind trust in AI creates the most risk.

Ethics

AI can optimise outcomes without understanding whether those outcomes are right or fair.

Context

AI lacks lived experience. It can miss cultural nuance, unspoken dynamics, and situational complexity.

Empathy

AI cannot genuinely understand how decisions affect real people emotionally or socially.

Strategic Judgement

Choosing the right direction — not just the optimal one — requires human wisdom.

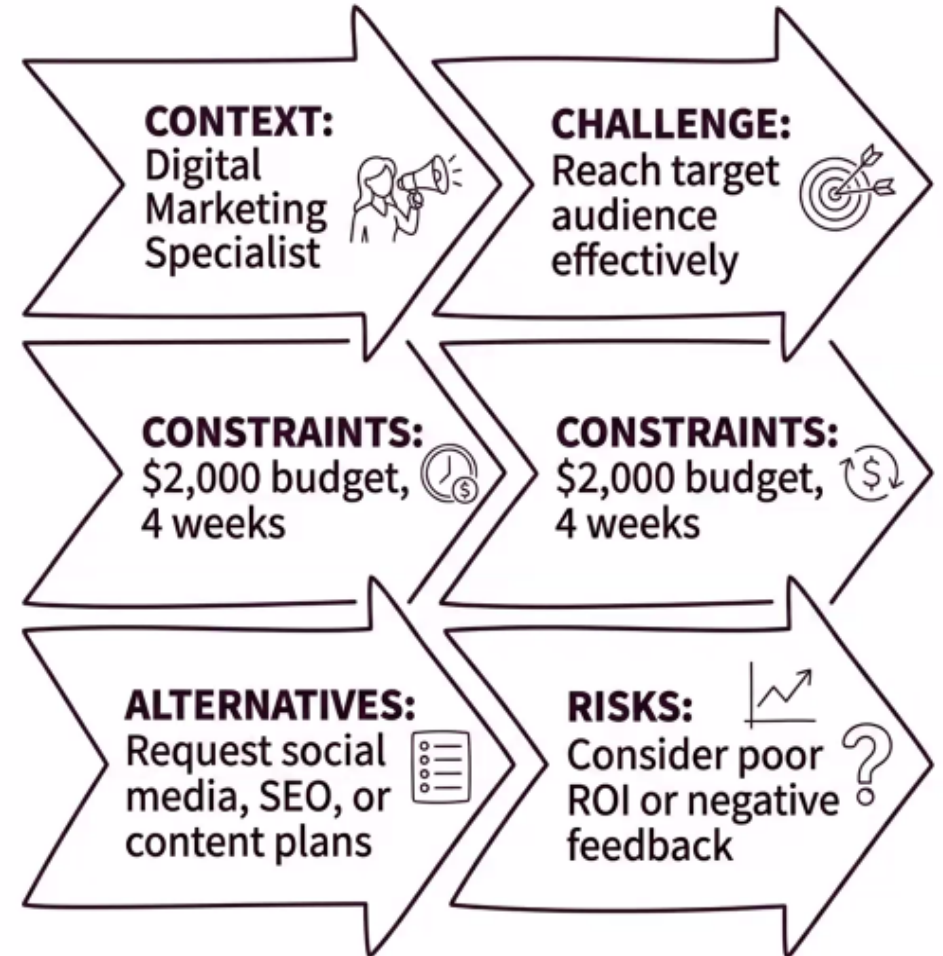
THE FIVE-PART PROMPT FORMULA

The quality of AI output is determined by the quality of your input. Use this five-part structure for consistently strong prompts:

Example Prompt

"I'm a product manager at a B2B SaaS company. We're experiencing high customer churn in the first 30 days. Budget is limited. Give me three onboarding improvement ideas and highlight the risks of each."

The more context and constraints you give, the more targeted and useful the AI response becomes.





Before You Launch Any Idea

Pause. Ask these three questions.

Who Benefits?

Is the value real and meaningful for the people this idea is meant to serve?

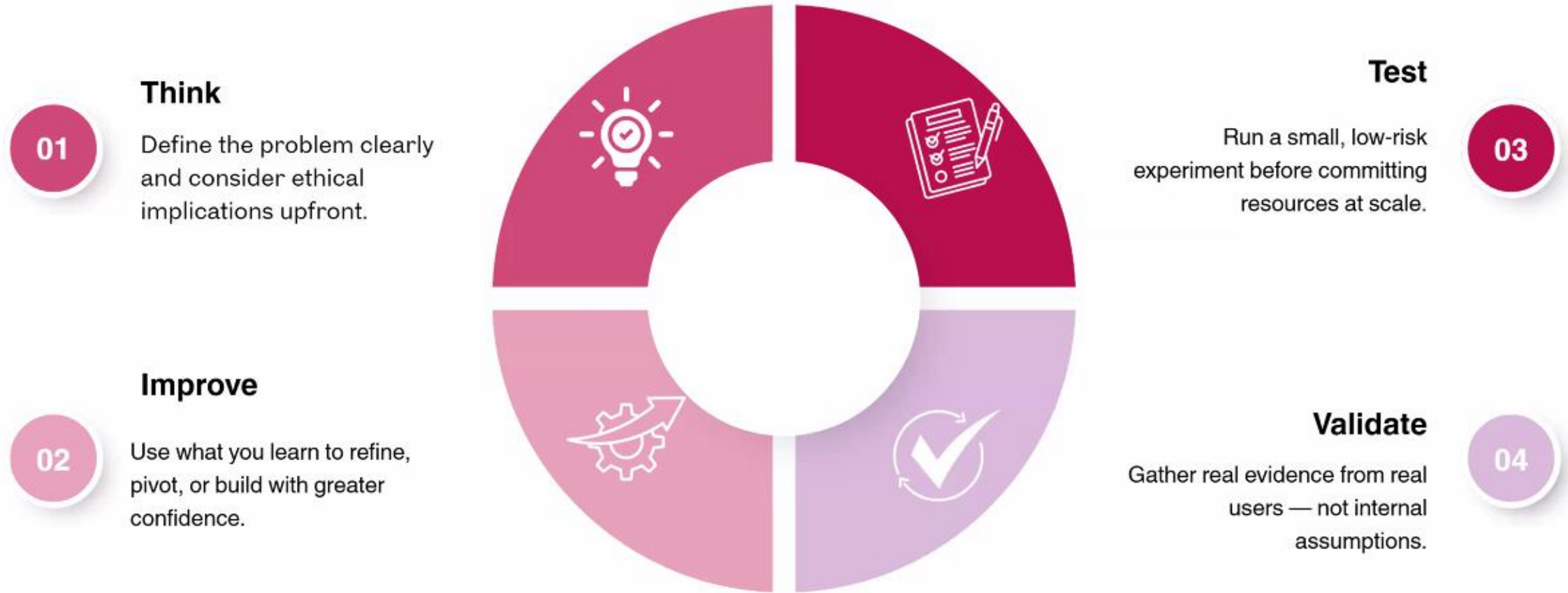
Who Could Be Harmed?

Consider unintended consequences — for customers, colleagues, and the wider community.

What Are We Assuming?

Name the beliefs your idea depends on — and test the most critical ones first.

INNOVATION + RESPONSIBILITY



Key Takeaways

- **Think Before Solving**

Slow down to understand the real problem — not just the most visible one.

- **Solve Root Causes**

Use the 5 Whys and problem statements to get beneath the surface.

- **Generate More Options**

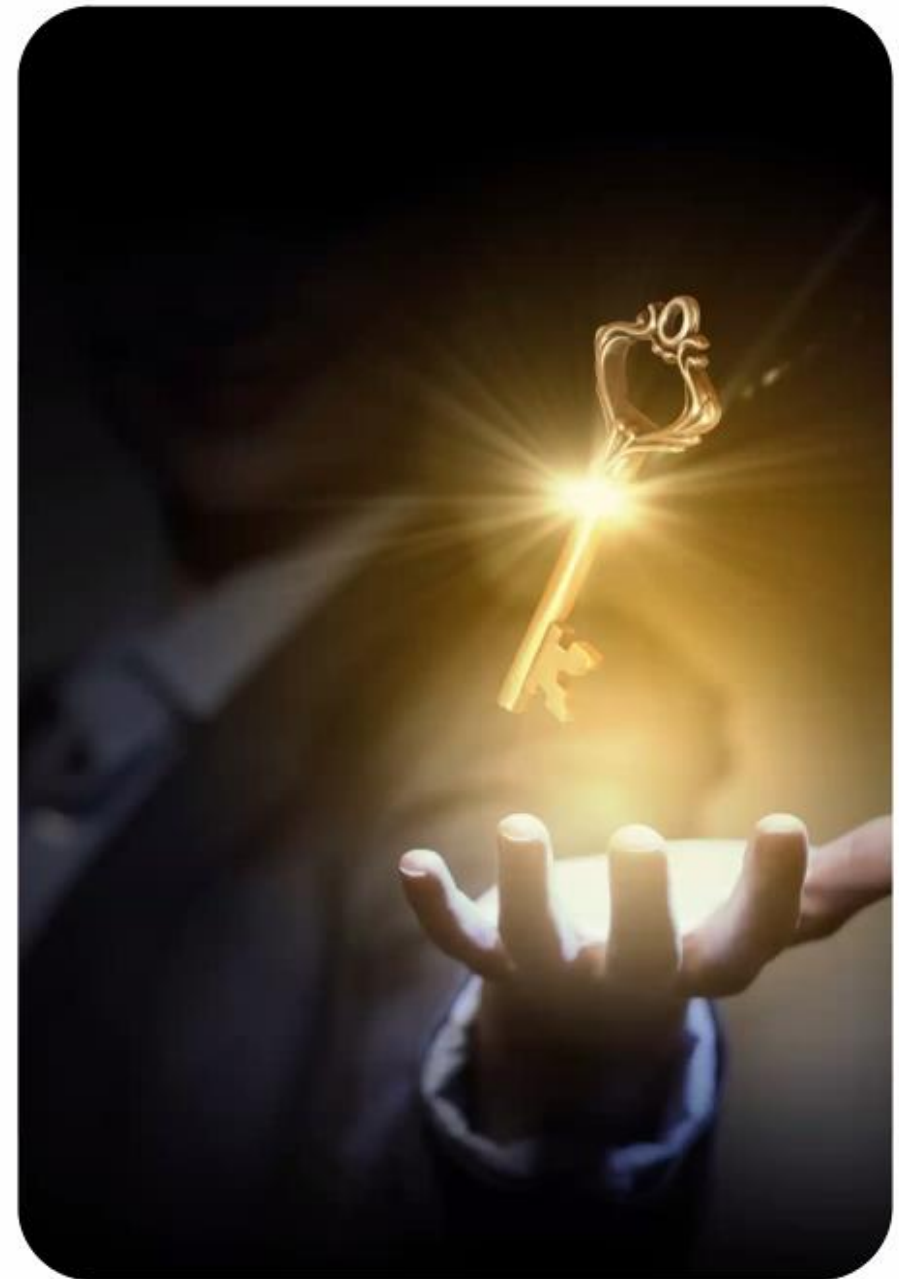
Use SCAMPER and "How Might We" to expand before you narrow.

- **Use AI Wisely**

Bring strong thinking to AI — and use it to amplify, not replace, your judgement.

- **Stay Curious**

The best innovators never stop questioning. Curiosity is a competitive advantage





Your 30-Day Challenge

Knowledge without action is just trivia. Choose one framework and apply it every week for the next 30 days.

5 Whys

Apply it to the next problem your team faces — before anyone suggests a solution.

SCAMPER

Run a 20-minute SCAMPER session on a current product, service, or process.

AI Prompting

Use the five-part prompt formula on a real challenge.
Compare AI output to your own thinking.

Small, consistent practice builds lasting capability. One framework, applied regularly, changes how you think.

The background features abstract, flowing shapes in various shades of pink and red, creating a dynamic and modern aesthetic. The shapes are layered, with some appearing more prominent than others, giving a sense of depth and movement.

THANK YOU

**Thank you for your time,
energy, and curiosity today.
The thinking starts now.**